VIJAY TAKES A HIT

The Karur rally stampede that took 41 lives has shaken up the Tamil superstar's fledgling political career. How he navigates this crisis will determine his future in TN politics

By KAVITHA MURALIDHARAN



INDIA PICTURE

IN HIS 2020 NOVELLA *VAAZHGA VAAZHGA*, Sahitya Akademi-winning writer Imayam ends with a haunting image: the weary cadre, including women and children, stand for hours in the scorching sun, hungry and drained, waiting for the Great Leader. When she arrives, chaos erupts. People collapse under the crush of the crowd. In the end, all that remains is the exhausted chant "*Vaazhga, vaazhga*... (Long live, long live)" rising from the emptiness.

Last week in Karur, that piece of fiction played out in real life: 41 fans of Tamil superhero-turned-neta Vijay, who had been waiting all day for a glimpse of the leader, were killed in a stampede. Over a hundred others were injured in the September 27 rally organised by his party, the Thamizhaga Vetri Kazhagam (TVK).

The cause of the tragedy itself was no mystery—the organisers had taken permission for a gathering of 10,000, but post-tragedy estimates suggest the crowd could have been three times the number. More than 5,000 supporters had followed Vijay from Namakkal—from where his cavalcade had started that day, the 14th day of his statewide tour. Thousands more streamed into the venue at Karur's Veluchamipuram, where he was supposed to reach by afternoon. Eager fans had staked out places since morning itself. But with multiple breaks en route, the star caravan arrived six hours late, at around 7 pm, by which time people had braved the scorching sun for several hours. News of him arrived first, and people climbed on top of trees and makeshift structures. As the long-awaited motorcade rolled in, the surge peaked. Structures gave way. Then chaos. Not long into the stampede, the actor was whisked away and remained incommunicado for three days.

Reel to Reality Check

Before the Karur tragedy, Vijay had been meticulously crafting his political persona. The strategy was clear: position himself as an alternative to the ruling Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) and stake claim as a decisive, combative leader.